

Judith Orloff

Paper on Change Assessment for Montessori
Teacher Training

ELC-726: Theories of Change

Assessment of Montessori Teacher Training using Theories of Change

“The training of the teacher is something far more than learning ideas. It includes training of character. It is a preparation of the spirit.” Marie Montessori

My interest in obtaining a doctorate at Fielding Graduate University is to pursue my dream and professional mission of “cracking the code” of childhood conditioning, particularly the negative beliefs and inner voices that continue to plague an individual throughout their lives.

My idea is to partner with other scholar practitioners, review the literature of programs and organizations wishing to dissolve negative childhood conditioning and develop a Mindfulness Curriculum for parents and children to facilitate this dream. I have called this curriculum Disruptive Learning Technology.

I have been interested in the Montessori Method of teacher training primarily because of its focus on self-awareness, self-assessment and observation through non-judgment. I decided to explore that through the lens of Theory of Change. The inquiry in this paper is, to see how Theories of Change can be used to explore the Montessori assessment schema to evaluate teacher's accomplishments in the Montessori educational model.

I will not compare the differences between traditional and Montessori teacher training. I also will not focus on the children schooled in Montessori education. Because of the nature of an assessment schema, it seems to me we are looking at skills that can be measured by observation and testing, and the Montessori Paradigm, which seems more difficult and elusive to assess.

We each have ontological restraints based on our background, and training and are conditioned at a very early age to evaluate rather than assess how progress is being made both in individual students and in organizations. However, in the Montessori method of teacher training, the most important skill demanded is for each teacher training candidate to learn to be mindful and inner directed as this is one of the most pronounced feature of Montessori Education.

“To be mindful is to be non-judgmental: one is to notice, but not make good-bad judgments. “Mindfulness is cultivated by assuring the stance of an impartial witness to your own experience. To do this requires that you become aware of the constant stream of judging...and learn to step back from it” (Kabat-Zinn 1990, p. 33).

For purposes of this assessment of change paper, assessment is the process of objectively understanding the state or condition of a thing, by observation and measurement. Assessment of teaching means taking a measure of its “effectiveness.” Whereas, Evaluation is the process of observing and measuring a thing to judging it and to determine its “value,” either by comparison to similar things, or to a standard. Evaluation of teaching means passing judgment on it as part of an administrative process. (institute for teaching learning and Academic leadership, University at Albany state university of New York.)

First, I will provide a simple definition of what Theory of Change is and how it will be used in this paper.

“A theory of change (TOC) is the product of a series of critical-thinking exercises that provide a comprehensive picture of the early- and intermediate-term changes in each community that are

needed to reach a long-term goal articulated by the community” (Anderson, A. 2005) It works like a roadmap of an area with different accesses to destinations, based on your speed, interest areas to visit and what your end goals are. If you proceed on your journey reaching the beginning landmarks and the intermediate landmarks, that will give you a clearer picture of whether you are taking the right road. (www.theoryofchange.org) what-is-Theory-of-change/#4) Anderson, Andrea; Harvard Family Research Project. Volume XI, Number 2, Summer 2005

The study of change and questions of how to manifest change for individuals and organizations have baffled experts (Deal, 1985; Kimberly and Quinn, 1984) Our assumptions about how change occurs, range from Darwin Gradualism, to punctuated equilibrium, which is that a species remains basically static and then abruptly there is a paradigm transformation like in Darwin’s thinking, where the species makes a shift and the species looks and feels different than before.

I personally subscribe to both change models, depending on what we are examining. In training leaders for large organizations, the first part of our work was to make sure we had a covenant on the long-term goals of the organization. Of course, this came after many interviews with stakeholders from all levels of the organization. We then created a critical path model and could change our assumptions as we moved through the program. The Montessori Teacher Training is quite consistent in what it expects from its teachers.

Montessori’s dominant oral tradition has been prominent since 1909 and focuses on culture, ideology and technique (Hiebert, Gallimore, & Stigler 2002) in learning to teach. Although there are no agreed upon definitions of theories of change, they can be used as a map toward supporting changes of all kinds. Therefore, it is important to make sure the Theory/s of Change we use in this paper make sense “as a response to analysis of the context, the problem/question and the changes needed. “using theory of change

as a framework to test assumptions, demonstrate impact and learn from it. (Isabel Vogal for the UK Department of International Development)

In all assessments for Montessori teacher training, there is a need for critical reflection as the process moves forward. Because the most important aspect of the training will depend on self- reflection and self-assessment. Theory of change can innovate and adapt to the changing dynamic conditions through making assumptions explicit and transparent at all steps of the process. Which assumptions are to be held? Which assumptions can be made in all the trainings? Montessori is an international model of childhood education, and there is a need for consistency as well as flexibility based on the culture where the program is delivered. When assumptions and near term and intermediate term goals are clear, they inform the design and implementation of the programs.

When plotting a theory of change to assess the long-term goals, the early and intermediate term changes are necessary to monitor to determine if the assumptions that were made originally are accurate, whether the logic (or tactics) continues to make sense and whether a change in the theory is necessary to go the next step. Because Theory of Change (TOC) is also a tool that can be used in many different contexts, ranging from large scale complex social action initiatives to assessing teacher training in the Montessori Method. we will utilize Theory of Change to assess the results of Montessori Teacher Training based on the stated goals of teacher performance.

I am not going to discuss the actual results of the Montessori educational model in terms how well the children in the program do, but rather will focus on the expected results of the teacher training.

I believe the philosopher Fritjof Capra in his description of a paradigm, makes sense when we look at an assessment of Montessori Teachers. “A paradigm is a constellation of concepts, values, perceptions and practices, shared by a community that forms a particular vision of reality that is the basis of the way the

community organizes itself. It's necessary for a paradigm to be shared by a community. A single person can have a worldview, but a paradigm is shared by a community." (The Web of Life, New York, Anchor Books, 1996) (Giles Hutchins, The nature of business April 12, 2014)

The Montessori approach to assessment and reporting is based on the belief that each child is a competent learner, born ready to learn from the people and the cultural and material environment around them. (Roemer, Kathy Lynn, May 1999 Dissertation EDD University of Memphis)

The guidelines for Montessori Elementary Teachers are clear in that they are to assess student's progress and achievement. However, this is not very well defined since it is very difficult to assess. Some Montessori Teachers use traditional measures such as standardized achievement tests and tests of memory and recall (McKenzie, 1998) Other Montessori Teachers use portfolios and individualized discussions and conferences for assessment.

In a telephone conversation with Ann Velasco, Director of Training for Southwest Institute for Montessori Studies, she said the most difficult aspect of the Montessori Teacher Training is the teachers need to learn about themselves. The two main foci of the training that I will look at with the Theory of Change are their main role which is setting the context of the classroom and being an observer. She said they need to come into the classroom every day with a fresh perspective, every day is a new day. Self-reflection and self-assessment are the pillars of their responsibilities. They have no hard and fast assessments for the teachers.

In a Montessori classroom, observation is one of the primary roles of the teacher. (Neubert, 1992). Observation is basic and significant to the Montessori method. Dr. Montessori referred to her approach as a "scientific pedagogy" (Montessori, 1962, p.21) with its foundation based on observation and experimentation. Teachers act more like facilitators and have the role of affirming each individual student in the classroom

The steps in the Theory of Change:

- 1. Start with what the teachers to learn. Identify a long-term goal. The skills based training of keeping a portfolio for each child, learning what the district needs for reporting, keeping an organizational schedule, assessing each child as they move along the pathway for their grade level.
- 2. Conduct “backwards mapping” to identify the preconditions necessary to achieve that goal. This is not done in the training. However, what does it take to become judgment free? What are the skills that are needed to observe without making conclusions and pinning labels on each child?
- 3. Identify the interventions that your initiative will perform to create these preconditions. “Theory of change is best kept flexible not prescribed” (Vogel, Isabel, April 2012) Because Theory of Change is both a process and a product, the decision of what it is depends on the steps in the process. It is most effective when overlaid on already existing processes, to support critical thinking throughout. The Montessori Teacher Training is individually prescribed within a global context and culture.

As discussed previously, the individual teacher spends most of her/his training learning about themselves as part of a larger universal culture so they can approach each child without positive or negative assumptions. In my interview with a Montessori trainer, she states this is the most difficult and most important aspect of the training.

- 4. Develop indicators for each precondition that will be used to assess the performance of the interventions. There are monthly self-assessments each teacher fills out. And, they are sent to observe in an already productive and successful setting. They may observe every day until they can approach

the classroom and the students in the classroom without their own assumptions as a precondition.

- 5. Write a narrative that can be used to summarize the various moving parts in your theory. There is a portfolio for each child that continues throughout their journey.

The Montessori approach to assessment and reporting reflect its pedagogy and philosophy, which is based on the belief that each child is a competent learner, born ready to learn from the people, cultural and material environment around them. (Roemer, Kathy Lynn, May 1999 Dissertation EDD, University of Memphis.)

The long-term goal for all Montessori Teachers is to create an environment/a context where they can be facilitators of the learning process for the educational process each child experiences.

The assumptions that will support the long-term goal seem to be as follows:

- Each teacher can be a competent learner.
- Each teacher can let go of judgements about themselves and their students.
- Conduct “backward mapping” to identify the preconditions necessary to achieve that goal

This could be presented in Critical Path sequencing of stages determining the minimum time needed for certain tasks, moving backward. I can see the first step of the Theory of Change of identifying the long-term goal of teachers to be able to create the appropriate context/environment for the students.

Accountability of meeting standards and ensuring the educational growth of every child has influenced the Montessori Method of Teaching. The public schools are held to meet or exceed assessment scores of all students in the school district. Montessori

needs to prove ensured educational growth for all students educated through the Montessori Method without being competitive.

Although working with the Theory of Change can be challenging, as it has been for me, its framework can evaluate potential issues before they are a problem. With a context of open communication and intimate discussion of each teacher's inner life as an intermediate goal in Montessori Training, an open approach to learning is welcomed.

Is Montessori a reform model of training and learning? (Argyris, C, 2000) Based on the emphasis of teachers being responsible for creating the context and environment of the classroom, it makes sense to look at the setting in which they work to see how Theories of Change can support their work. (Elmore, R. 2004) Many standard school reform practices in traditional settings seem to be lacking in the core instructional goals of the teacher. They were more focused on student outcomes and achievement levels. (Cross City Campaign, 2005, p.23) Of course, this is crucial. Chicago, Milwaukee and Seattle all had their focus on standardized results. They were not focused on the classroom culture. "The standards were rarely connected to changes in instruction. (Cross City Campaign, 2005, p.69)

Michael Fullan makes the case that Theories of Change need an upgrade to Theories of Action (p.8, Centre for Strategic Education, 2006) He believes there needs to be a focus on motivation with an emphasis on moral purpose. Montessori Teacher Education certainly emphasizes motivation and moral purpose. The rest of his bullet points are capacity; resources; peer and leadership support, and identity. His belief that most theories of change are weak on capacity building does not hold true in the Montessori Teacher Training.

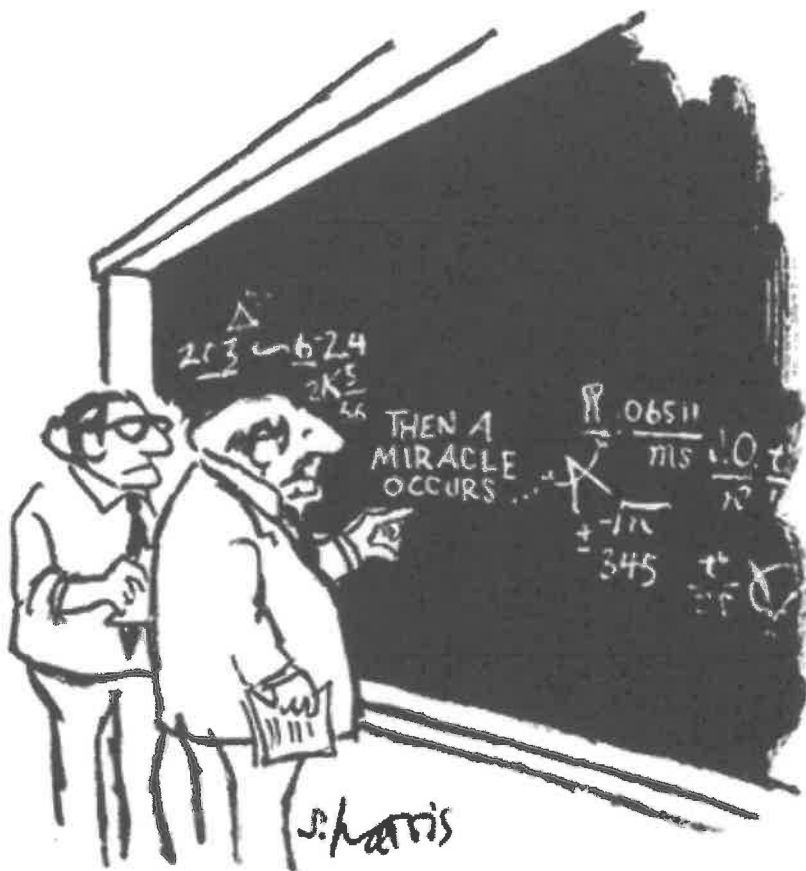
His Theories of Action upgrade where people learn in context, he says, "changes the very context itself. Contexts do improve. He also emphasizes the need for reflective action. Again, Montessori Teacher Training was made for his Theory of Action.

The following pages are an appendix to the paper:

P. 18, A cartoon which I thought made total sense as I wrote this paper.

P. 19-21, A Model for Change that I developed while CEO at Educational Discoveries, a Leadership and Development Company

P. 23, An activity that could foster Change in the Classroom



"I think you should be more explicit here in step two."

Theory of Change Academic Formula

Model for Change – Judith Orloff M.Ed. – Developed when CEO of Educational Discoveries, 2001

1. Go Getter (Seeker) - The Seeker's job is to navigate through the Model for Change (or whatever we decide to call it). They understand that change comes only after moving through a process, and they must be willing to experience uncertainty around how they have been conditioned to respond and react.

2. Support (Supporter) - The Supporter is a source of strength for the Seeker. It reminds the Seeker of their commitment and keeps them grounded and connected to their vision through any chaos. The Supporter is not afraid to say things as they are, nor is it afraid of any reactions that may take place.

3. Intention - Always aligns with the will of the Seeker, no matter where it leads. It will always yield to the Seeker's task.

4. Business as Usual-Status quo- It is an established and conservative way of doing things. It knows what has always worked in the past and has no interest in change.

5. Decision to Change - There is a recognition of the need to change, whether it is prompted by an inner desire or an external situation.

6. Resistance - Resistance is the result of a decision to change. It comes from fear of loss and seems rigid and immovable.

7. Order - It appears rational because it assesses the risks of moving into unfamiliar territory that always comes with change. Order wants everything to stay the same.

8. Chaos - Chaos is the catalyst for change and is filled with the unknown. The Seeker finds themselves pulled between the powers of order and chaos.

9. Reaction - Reaction is what occurs when we feel threatened and are not aware of the feelings we are trying to protect. It is a powerful force because it is coming from the past instead of allowing the truth of the moment to happen.

10. Illusion - It represents what is most familiar. It likes to be comfortable and stays in state of “everything is the way it should be.”

11. Crisis - Crisis is the moment of truth. As Danger, it threatens the existence of the Seeker, and as Opportunity it propels the Seeker to get back on track.

12. Congruence - Walking the talk. When attitudes and actions are consistent with purpose and vision.

13. Ability to Receive New Information - Open-Minded?) - This is one of the most essential skills needed for change. It allows new information in to dissolve conditioned responses and allow for new solutions.

14. Synergy (Harmony or Unity) - When two or more energies come together to achieve a higher goal.

15. Chaos of Creation

- As risk
- As naked truth
- As paradox
- As the unknown
- As fear

As excitement

Personal Freedom - If the Seeker utilizes choice, change, and power in the right ways, personal freedom will come as a result. It is the most powerful way of being that the Seeker has, manifesting itself as empowerment, partnering, and spontaneity.

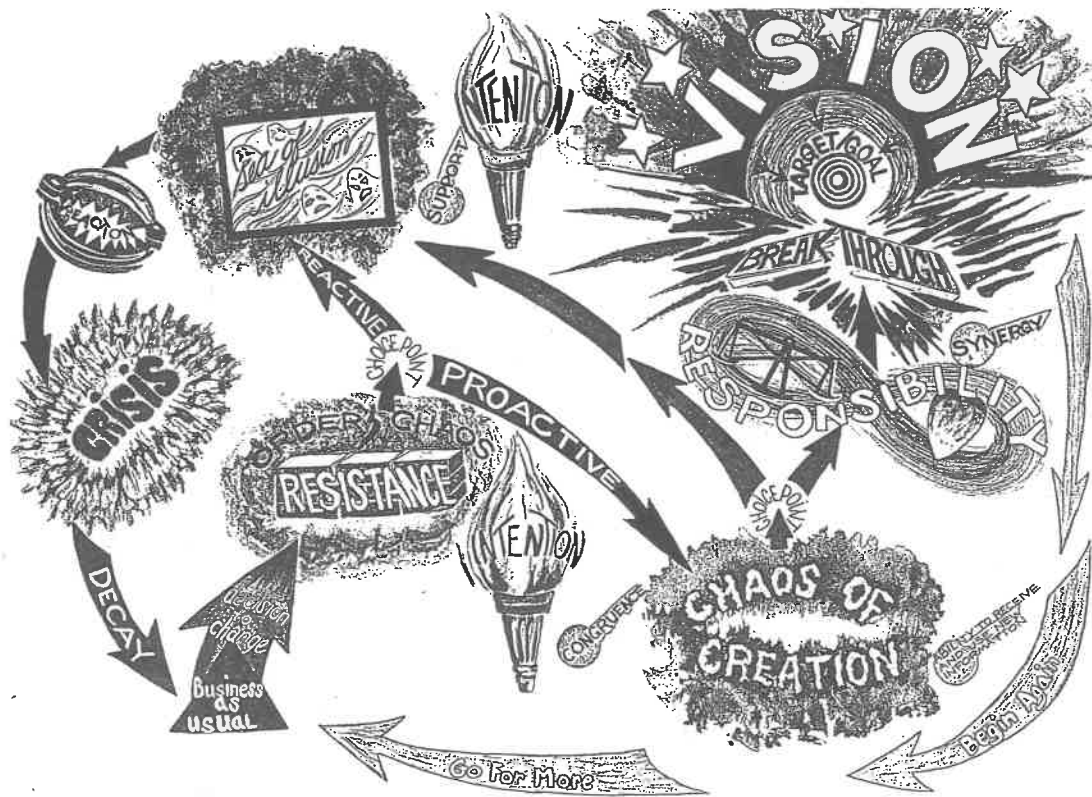
17. Personal Responsibility - Personal Responsibility sees itself as the source of its results. It knows that it is the source and authority of its experiences.

18. Objectives - Objectives are specific, measurable targets that the Seeker aims for. They measure whether the Seeker is on track toward their mission and vision.

19. Breakthrough - The breakthrough is the last barrier between the Seeker and change. In order for the breakthrough to occur, the Seeker must let go of the past.

20. Mission - The Mission is the purpose of the organization, the reason why it exists. It encompasses the values and culture of the organization.

21. Vision - It is the picture of the Seeker's purpose brought to life. It is the guiding light that continuously inspires the Seeker to realize their highest purpose.



MODEL FOR CHANGE

Championing Change Activity Feedback Form

Take Ownership
Remove Barriers
Manage Risk
Foster New Ideas and Innovation

Criteria	January	April	July	October	Final Assessment
Was the strategy clearly presented?					
Were the roles and responsibilities articulated?					
Were the barriers to success removed?					
Were the risks identified and accounted for?					
Was it innovative?					
Was the plan flexible in terms of expanding the possibilities for others to be innovative and empowered?					
Were you moved to take ownership for the change?					

I believe this activity could support Theories of Change to be
Theories of Action in any Teacher Training Session

Judith Orloff, M.Ed.

References:

Assessment of change in Montessori Teacher Training

Change theory, A force for school improvement, Fullan, Michael
Center for Strategic Education; Seminar Series Paper No. 157,
November 2006

Criteria for assessing the evaluability of Theories of Change
Davies, Rick; Blog Post

Culture, Craft & Coherence; the Unexpected Vitality of Montessori
Teacher Training; Journal of Teacher Education 60(5)520-527
Sage Publications 2009
Cossentino, J. Principal of CREC Montellori Magnet School

ECD Theory of Change. Htt; [://maryblackfoundation.org](http://maryblackfoundation.org), 2014

An Introduction to Theory of Change/Evaluation Methodology/Issue
Archive/Volume XI, Number 2, Summer 2005

Montessori Approach vs. Traditional Approach to Assessment
TeachingonPurpose.org

Revolutionary Change Theories: A Multilevel Exploration of the
Punctuated Equilibrium Paradigm
Gersick, Connie J.G., The Academy of Management Review; pp 10-36
Issn: 0363-7425

A Theory of socio-ecological system change; R. Constanza
Journal of Bioeconomics
ISSN; 1387-6996, 1573-6989
4/20/14

Re-visioning-Action: Participatory Action Research and Indigenous Theories of Change; the Urban review; Dordrecht, Volume 41, 1, pp. 47-65, March 2009

Tuck, Eve Published Online -23 September 2008@ Springer Science+Business Media, LLC 2008

Theory of Change Tool Manual;
International Network on Strategic Philanthropy
May 2005

Theory-based Methodology: Using theories of change for development, research and evaluation, edited by Karen Laing and Lix Todd, September 2015

Theory of Change: A Practical Tool for Action, Results and Learning
Prepared for Annie E. Casey Foundation; prepared by Organization Research Services 2004

The differences Between Concepts, Theories and Paradigms
David Sarokin, Sciencing, Leaf Group Ltd,

Theory of Change vs Logical Framework – What's the Difference?

The Art of Assessment in the Montessori Classroom, Prezi
Montessori Teacher Self Reflection and Self-Assessment:
Constructive Goal Setting and Feedback; Irinyl, Michelle

Primary – Early Childhood Course, The Center for Guided Montessori Studies

Mindfulness Practices in Education: Montessori's Approach, Lillard, Angeline.S. 2011/06/01

References:

Change theory, A force for school improvement, Fullan, Michael
Center for Strategic Education; Seminar Series Paper No. 157,
November 2006

Culture, Craft & Coherence; the Unexpected Vitality of Montessori
Teacher Training; Journal of Teacher Education 60(5)520-527
Sage Publications 2009
Cossentino, J. Principal of CREC Montellori Magnet School

Revolutionary Change Theories: A Multilevel Exploration of the
Punctuated Equilibrium Paradigm
Gersick, Connie J.G., The Academy of Management Review; pp 10-36
Issn: 0363-7425

Criteria for assessing the evaluability of Theories of Change
Davies, Rick; Blog Post

A Theory of socio-ecological system change; R. Constanza

Journal of Bioeconomics
ISSN; 1387-6996, 1573-6989
4/20/14

Re-visioning-Action: Participatory Action Research and Indigenous
Theories of Change
Tuck, Eve Published Online -23 September 2008@
Springer Science+Business Media, LLC 2008

Theory of Change Tool Manual;
International Network on Strategic Philanthropy
May 2005

Theory-based Methodology: Using theories of change for
development, research and evaluation, edited by Karen Laing and
Lix Todd, September 2015

Theory of Change: A Practical Tool for Action, Results and Learning
Prepared for Annie E. Casey Foundation; prepared by Organization
Research Services 2004

The differences Between Concepts, Theories and Paradigms
David Sarokin, Sciencing, Leaf Group Ltd,

Theory of Change vs Logical Framework - What's the Difference?

The Art of Assessment in the Montessori Classroom, Prezi
Montessori Teacher Self Reflection and Self-Assessment:
Constructive Goal Setting and Feedback; Irinyl, Michelle

Montessori Approach vs. Traditional Approach to Assessment

Montessori Guide

No.	Slide – suggest very colorful graphics, pictures and video	Talking Points – suggestions on topics to cover while slide is shown.
1	Opening	
2	Children with special needs are just like you in many ways. But they may be lacking your: • Physical coordination • Mental capacity or • Emotional stability	Right here in our Jewish community there are many children with special needs. They may be learning disabled, unable to see or hear or be mentally impaired. There are many different reasons why children of all ages have special needs.
3	In addition to the love and support these children receive at home, they need: • Education, • Therapy and • A Social life	Maybe you've had children with special needs in your classes, or they may go to another school that is designed to meet their needs. Therapy is something you may be familiar with; it's usually a regular session where a child goes to get the physical or emotional support they need from a professional. These two needs are pretty easy for parents to fill; they can find the right school and therapist for their son or daughter. <i>But what about social needs?</i>
4	Everybody needs friends! That's why we created the Friendship Circle.	Let's see a show of hands. How many of you hung out with friends over the weekend? How many talked to a friend on the phone last night? Sometimes it's difficult for a child with special needs to make a connection with other kids. That's why we created the Friendship Circle. The Friendship Circle is about teens like you getting together with children with special needs.
5	The Friendship Circle has three great programs: 1. Friends at Home 2. Children's Circle 3. Holiday and Camp Programs	The Friendship Circle offers you a choice. You can get involved a little or a lot. And there are special trips just for volunteers (more on that later). I will review each of these three programs because you may just find a place for yourself in one of them.
6	Friends at Home You and a friend visit a child weekly	Hey, this is a big commitment with a huge payoff! You pair up with a friend of yours and together you visit a child in his or her home once a week. Don't worry about whether you can do it – you'll be trained before you begin your work as a friend and mentor. The payoff? An amazing feeling of pride and satisfaction. The 100 teens already doing it love it!
7	Children's Circle Sunday is party time	This is fun! For 15 Sundays during the school year the whole group comes together. You will volunteer to be with other teens

		and the children while they participate in some of their (and your) favorite activities like music, art, storytelling and sports.
8	Holiday and Camp Programs Cool gatherings all year long	It's time to Celebrate! On Jewish Holidays children with special needs and their families join for festivities and traditions. Winter camps and other occasional programs are also held. Volunteers like you are needed for these events.
9	Here's a quick review: 1. Friends at Home 2. Children's Circle 3. Holiday and Camp Programs	Three programs. Three great opportunities for fun and mitzvah! Friends at Home – a weekly visit to a child Children's Circle – a large gathering on Sundays Holiday and Camp Programs – occasional group events.
10	Bonus! Special events for you.	Here are those special events I told you about. As a volunteer you get the rewards of being a friend and mentor, you get special training, great experience (impressive! looks good on college applications) plus free trips like rafting and skiing.
11	Remember: Be a friend!	What do you think, ready to join the Friendship Circle? Just sign up after this session and we'll call you to tell you more. If you're not ready to volunteer we still hope that you will keep in mind that children with special needs are a lot like you. They also need friends. Think about giving a big smile or lending a hand to someone whom may need your friendship today.
12	Final tied to opening	